

A CRITICAL SURVEY OF INDIAN PHILOSOPHY

C. D. SHARMA — STUDY NOTES

# ŚAṆKARA'S ADVAITA VEDĀNTA

## *Part 2 — The Positive Exposition*

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Chapter X · Māyā and Brahman | Chapter XI · Īśvara and Brahman  
Chapter XII · Jīva and Brahman | Chapter XIII · Ātman and Brahman  
Chapter XIV · Knowledge and Action | Chapter XV · Knowledge and Liberation  
Chapter XVI · Ultimate Criterion of Truth

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Continuation of Part 1 (dialectical criticism of rival schools). This part covers Śaṅkara's own positive system: the metaphysics of Māyā/Avidyā, the Brahman-Īśvara-Jīva-Ātman structure, the doctrine of jñāna-karma-virodha, the nature of liberation, and the epistemology of Śruti, reason, and intuition as criteria of truth.

## CHAPTER X

# MĀYĀ AND BRAHMAN

### 1. The Central Formula of Advaita

*The entire system of Advaita Vedānta is traditionally compressed into half a verse: brahma satyaṁ jagan mithyā jīvo brahmaiva nāparaḥ — Brahman is the only Reality; the world is ultimately false; and the individual soul is non-different from Brahman.*

Brahman and Ātman, or the Supreme Self, are synonymous terms. The world is a creation of Māyā. Individual selves, on account of their inherent Avidyā, imagine themselves as different from Brahman and mistake Brahman for this world of plurality — exactly as one mistakes a rope for a snake. Avidyā vanishes only at the dawn of knowledge, understood as the supra-relational, direct and intuitive knowledge of the non-dual Self, which constitutes liberation itself.

### 2. The Terminological Landscape

A cluster of terms is used almost interchangeably throughout Vedānta: Māyā, Avidyā, Ajñāna, Adhyāsa, Adhyāropa, Anirvacanīya, Vivarta, Bhrānti, Bhrama, Nāma-rūpa, Avyakta, Akṣara, Bija-śakti, and Mūla-prakṛti. Of these, Māyā, Avidyā, Adhyāsa and Vivarta are the most often used as strict synonyms. Later Advaitins split into two schools over whether Māyā and Avidyā name one thing or two.

#### **(a) The dominant school — Māyā and Avidyā as one, distinguished only by aspect**

The general trend among the Advaitins, including Śaṅkara himself, is to treat Māyā and Avidyā as synonymous, while distinguishing two *aspects* of the same power: **āvaraṇa**, the negative aspect of concealment, and **vikṣepa**, the positive aspect of projection.

#### **(b) The rival school — Māyā and Avidyā as genuinely distinct**

A second school insists Māyā and Avidyā differ in kind:

(1) Māyā is something *positive* — an essentially indistinguishable power (śakti) of Brahman, absolutely dependent on and inseparable from Him. Avidyā, by contrast, is entirely *negative* in character — pure ignorance, the mere absence of knowledge of Reality.

(2) Māyā, the cosmic power of projection, conditions Īśvara, who is untouched by Avidyā; Avidyā, the individual ignorance, conditions the Jīva. Brahman reflected in Māyā is Īśvara; Brahman reflected in Avidyā is the Jīva.

*Footnote cited: kāryopādhir ayaṁ jīvaḥ kāraṇopādhir Īśvaraḥ — the Jīva has the effect (Māyā's product) as its limiting adjunct, Īśvara has the cause as its limiting adjunct.*

(3) Consequently, though individual ignorance is dispelled by knowledge, Māyā — being the inherent nature of Brahman itself — cannot be so dispelled.

(4) Māyā is made predominantly of *sattva*; Avidyā is made of all three guṇas — sattva, rajas, and tamas together.

Sharma's assessment: the two schools are not really opposed. Whether Māyā is called the cosmic, positive power of projection and Avidyā the individual, negative ignorance, or whether Māyā and Avidyā are simply treated as synonymous with two aspects of concealment and projection, the fundamental position remains identical. Both schools further agree that Īśvara is ever free from the negative aspect of Ignorance, and that sattva preponderates in Him. Whether concealment is called Avidyā or Tūlāvidyā and projection Māyā or Mūlāvidyā, the difference is only verbal.

### 3. Śaṅkara's Nine Characteristics of Māyā/Avidyā

Sharma draws together the defining marks Śaṅkarācārya attributes to Māyā or Avidyā:

- (1) **Material and unconscious** (jaḍā) — like the Prakṛti of Sāṅkhya, it stands opposed to Brahman (as Puruṣa stands opposed to Prakṛti in Sāṅkhya), which is Pure Consciousness. Unlike Prakṛti, however, Māyā is neither real nor independent.
- (2) **The inherent Power or Potency (Śakti) of Brahman** — coeval with Him, absolutely dependent on and inseparable from Him, non-different (ananyā) from Him. The relation between Māyā and Brahman is unique and is called *tādātmya*: neither identity, nor difference, nor both. Māyā is energised and acts as the medium for the projection of the world of plurality upon the non-dual ground of Brahman.
- (3) **Beginningless** (anādi).
- (4) **Positive** (bhāvarūpā), though not real. It is called positive precisely to emphasise that it is not merely negative. It has two aspects: in its negative aspect it *conceals* (āvaraṇa) Reality, acting as a screen to hide it; in its positive aspect it *projects* (vikṣepa) the world of plurality upon the Brahman-ground. It is thus both non-apprehension and misapprehension.
- (5) **Indescribable and indefinable** (anirvacanīyā) — neither real, nor unreal, nor both (*sadasadanirvacanīyā*). It is not real, for it vanishes at the dawn of knowledge; it is not unreal, for it is true as long as it lasts; it is not real, for that would make it a genuine limit upon Brahman, and yet it is real enough to give rise to the world of appearance; and it is not both real and unreal together, since that conception is self-contradictory.
- (6) **Phenomenal and relative in character** (vyāvahārikasattā) — it is an appearance only (*vivarta*).
- (7) **Of the nature of superimposition** (adhyāsa) — an error (bhrānti) exactly like the rope-snake or the shell-silver. It is the superimposition of the character of one thing upon another; it is wrong cognition, misapprehension.
- (8) **Removable by Right Knowledge** (vijñānanirasyā) — when Vidyā dawns, Avidyā vanishes, exactly as the 'rope-snake' vanishes the moment the rope is recognised as a rope.
- (9) **Its locus (āśraya) and its object (viṣaya) are both Brahman** — and yet Brahman is really untouched by it, just as a magician is unaffected by his own magic, or the colourless ākāśa remains untouched by the dark colour popularly attributed to it.

#### 4. The Mechanism of Superimposition (Adhyāsa)

It is self-evident, says Śaṅkara, that the subject and the object are absolutely opposed to each other like light and darkness. The subject is Pure Consciousness; the object is Unconsciousness. The subject is the ultimate 'I'; the object is the 'non-I'. Neither these two, nor their attributes, can ever be legitimately identified with one another.

Yet it is the natural and universal practice of people to wrongly superimpose the object and its attributes upon the subject, and, conversely, the subject and its attributes upon the object. This co-mingling of subject and object, this mixing up of truth and error (*satyānrte mithunīkṛtya*), is what is called **superimposition** (adhyāsa), or **error** (bhrama), or **illusion** (māyā), or **ignorance** (avidyā). All definitions of error agree on this single point: error is the superimposition of the character of one thing upon another — as when silver is superimposed on shell, or when a single moon is seen doubled.

This superimposition is what the learned call 'ignorance'; the realisation of the true nature of reality, achieved by discarding the error, is what they call 'knowledge'. This transcendental Ignorance is the presupposition of all practices of the phenomenal world whatsoever. Superimposition, therefore, is precisely the notion of a thing in something else (*atasmin tadbuddhiḥ*). This beginningless cycle of superimposition generates the false notions of the agent and the enjoyer and, through them, all phenomenal practices. The entire study of the Vedānta texts is undertaken solely in order to free oneself from this false notion of superimposition and thereby to realise the essential unity of the Self.

*Cited from the Introduction to the Śārīraka-Bhāṣya, I, 1, 1.*

Sharma stresses that this superimposition is not secondary or figurative (*gauṇa*) in Śaṅkara's account — it is really false (*mithyā*). It is, he notes, pitiable that even learned people confuse the subject and the object in this way, no better in this respect than ordinary goatherds and shepherds.

#### 5. Ignorance as the Antecedent State of the World

Śaṅkara does not admit any antecedent state of the world as its *independent* cause. What is admitted is only an antecedent state of the world *dependent on Īśvara*. This state is called Nescience or Ignorance (avidyā). It is the germinal power or causal potentiality (bīja-śakti); it is unmanifest (avyakta); it depends on Īśvara (*parameśvarāśraya*); it is illusion (māyāmayī); it is the universal sleep (*mahāsupti*) in which worldly souls slumber, forgetting their own real nature.

All difference whatsoever is due to Ignorance and is therefore not ultimate. Names and forms (*nāmarūpe*) are mere figments of Ignorance — themselves neither real nor unreal. Īśvara, limited by His own power of Nescience, appears as the many phenomenal selves, exactly as space appears divided into different 'spaces' by the adjuncts of jars. The omniscience, omnipresence and omnipotence attributed to Īśvara are likewise all due to the adjuncts of Ignorance and are not ultimate — where the essential unity of the Ātman is realised, they all vanish together. Creation, therefore, is due to Ignorance, and is not ultimately real.

## 6. Māyā as Positive Wrong Knowledge

Māyā is not merely the absence of knowledge; it is also *positive* wrong knowledge (mithyācārarūpā). It is not only non-apprehension but also misapprehension. It makes the infinite appear finite; it produces the manifold phenomena when in fact only the non-dual Ātman exists; it makes the unlimited Ātman appear as limited jīvas; it produces the false notions of plurality and difference. Yet it is not a real characteristic of Ātman or Brahman, since it is destroyed by true knowledge exactly as the rope-snake is sublated by knowledge of the rope. Brahman, through Avidyā, appears as the manifold world of names and forms, precisely as pure water appears as dirty foam.

Śaṅkara treats questions such as 'What is Avidyā? Whose is Avidyā? Where does it appear?' as essentially useless (*nirarthaka*): if Avidyā is not known, such questions cannot be solved; and if the true nature of Avidyā is realised, its locus and object are thereby already realised too. Brahman itself is both the locus and the object of Avidyā.

Avidyā is the darkening power (*tāmasa-pratyaya*); its essential nature is to cover or hide the real (*āvaraṇātmakatvādividyā*). It operates in three distinct ways:

- as **positive wrong knowledge** (viparītagrāhikā);
- as **doubt** (saṁśayopasthāpikā);
- as mere **absence of knowledge** (agrahaṇātmikā).

In reality it can do no harm whatsoever to Reality itself, just as mirage-water cannot actually make the sandy desert muddy.

## 7. The Repertoire of Similes and the Question of Mahāyāna Influence

The phenomenal world is repeatedly condemned by Śaṅkara as unreal, in a manner that closely echoes the spirit of Mahāyāna Buddhism and of Gauḍapāda. Śaṅkara draws on an extensive stock of similes: mirage-water (marīcyambhaḥ), rope-snake (raju-sarpa), shell-silver (śukti-rajata), the dusty surface of the sky (ākāśa-talamalinatā), the city of the Gandharvas (Gandharvanagara), illusion (māyā), the plantain-trunk (kadālī-garbha), dream (svapna), bubble (jala-budbuda), foam (phena), the moving fire-brand (alāta-cakra), the magical elephant (māyānirmīta-hastī), the hair or floating specks seen by defective vision (keśondraka; timiradṛṣṭi), the illusion of the double-moon (dvicandradaśana), and pure magic (Indra-jāla).

Sharma is careful to note that, like Gauḍapāda, Śaṅkara uses a great many words that were also current in Mahāyāna vocabulary. These words, however, belonged to the heritage of common philosophical language of the age and were not the monopoly of Mahāyāna Buddhism; their presence in Śaṅkara only proves the general influence of the intellectual climate of the period upon him, not any doctrinal borrowing. Many passages in Śaṅkara can nonetheless be closely compared with specific Buddhist writings — for instance, where Śaṅkara describes the phenomena of the cycle of birth-and-death as beset with countless evils, mutually producing one another like seed and sprout, unreal like the plantain-trunk, illusion, mirage, sky-castle, dream, bubble and foam, perishing every instant, born of ignorance and attachment, and constituted of subject and object, merit and demerit — concluding that a Brāhmaṇa who truly knows such phenomena for what they are should practice renunciation. Similarly,

Śaṅkara describes the beginningless saṃsāra, which is of the nature of suffering and rooted in Ignorance, as resembling a continually flowing stream of water; and compares the world of plurality, imagined through Ignorance, to the double-moon or floating specks seen by a person of defective vision, or to the many things a dreamer sees in a dream. From the Absolute, this world-illusion is said to expand exactly as a magical illusion expands from a magician — while the Absolute itself remains, in the end, wholly untouched by it.

## 8. The World Is Not Utterly Unreal — The Three Standpoints

Sharma's crucial qualification: the world is not condemned as utterly unreal even by Mahāyāna Buddhism and Gauḍapāda, let alone by Śaṅkara. The similes are metaphors and must not be stressed beyond their breaking-point. The world is only an *appearance*; it is not ultimately real, and it becomes sublated when knowledge dawns — but so long as we remain within this world, we cannot treat it as unreal. It is a practical reality, a workable hypothesis that is 'absolutely necessary, though in the end most indefensible.' Far from condemning the world, Śaṅkara grants some degree of reality even to error and illusion: 'No appearance is so low that the Absolute does not embrace it.' It is the Real which appears, and hence every appearance carries some degree of truth in it, even though none is absolutely true.

The dream analogy is developed at length: objects seen in a dream are quite real as long as the dream lasts — water in a dream can quench thirst in the dream. It is only upon waking that we can realise the falsity of the dream-state. Likewise, so long as a rope is mistaken for a snake, that mistaken cognition is sufficient to frighten the person who holds it; only when the rope is recognised for what it is can the person laugh at his own folly. Similarly, so long as we are engrossed in Ignorance, the world is quite real for us; it is only when true Knowledge dawns that the world becomes sublated. Just as foam, bubbles, ripples and waves exist separately, though in fact none of them differs from water, so too do the subject and the object, the enjoyer and the enjoyed, exist separately, though in fact they are not different from Brahman. The manifold world of experience is the effect; the highest Brahman is the cause; and the effect has no independent existence apart from its cause. Plurality of effects is, therefore, only a creation of Ignorance.

## 9. Can Unreal Māyā Cause the Real Brahman to Appear? — The First Objection

**Objection:** How can an unreal Māyā cause the real Brahman to appear as the phenomenal world at all? And how can false personalities, through false means, ever reach a true end?

**Śaṅkara's reply** proceeds by analogy: a person entangled in mud can get himself out only with the help of more mud; a thorn pricked into the body can be extracted only with the help of another thorn; and there are many instances in ordinary life showing that even unreal things can cause real effects — a reflection in a mirror is itself unreal, yet it can correctly represent the object reflected in it; the roaring of a tiger in a dream is unreal, yet it may make the dreamer tremble with genuine fear and may even wake him up. The objection loses its force once it is remembered that the manifold world is

taken to be real only so long as the essential unity of the Jīva with Brahman remains unrealised. As long as this knowledge has not dawned, all secular and religious practices are, and must be, taken as real.

## 10. The Opponent's Dilemma and Śaṅkara's Rebuttal

The opponent presses further: if the world is unreal, then unreal means — such as the Vedānta texts themselves — cannot possibly lead to real liberation; but if the world is real, it cannot be Māyā at all. The dilemma offered is stark: either frankly admit that the world is real, or else admit that a philosophy which has nothing better to offer than unreal personalities unreally striving, in an unreal world, through unreal means, to attain an unreal end, is itself wholly unreal. After all, one bitten by a rope-snake does not die from it, nor can anyone actually drink or bathe in mirage-water.

**Śaṅkara's reply:** if a person merely *imagines* himself bitten by a poisonous snake, and the imagination is sufficiently strong, it may nevertheless result in genuine heart-failure or real psychological collapse. Likewise, water drunk in a dream can quench thirst within the dream, and a person bitten by a snake in a dream may genuinely feel himself dead within that dream. Even unreal things, therefore, demonstrably cause real effects.

The deeper diagnosis Śaṅkara offers is that the opponent has hopelessly confused two distinct standpoints — the empirical and the absolute — even as he simultaneously confuses the merely imaginary with the empirical. The unreality of the effects belonging to the **imaginary standpoint** (prātibhāsika) can be realised only when the **empirical standpoint** (vyāvahārika) has been attained; and, exactly parallel to this, the unreality of the empirical standpoint itself can be realised only from the **absolute standpoint** (pāramārthika). The falsity of the dream-objects is realised only when the dreamer wakes up — and yet, even then, though the dream-objects themselves are sublated, the very *consciousness* that the dreamer had experienced those objects in the dream is not sublated even in the waking state. Consciousness is, therefore, eternal and real. Right knowledge is consequently not useless: firstly, because it removes ignorance, and secondly, because it can never itself be sublated. It is only from the absolute standpoint — once right knowledge is actually attained — that Vedānta declares the world to be unreal.

## 11. What 'Real' and 'Unreal' Actually Mean for Śaṅkara

Many critics, Sharma notes, have failed to grasp the true significance of Māyā or Avidyā and have consequently charged Śaṅkara with simply explaining the world away. This charge, however, rests on an illicit shifting of standpoints. As shown above, Śaṅkara grants some degree of reality even to dreams, illusions and errors. The terms 'real' and 'unreal' are used by Śaṅkara strictly in their *absolute* sense: 'real' means **real for all time**, and Brahman alone can be real in this sense; 'unreal' means **absolutely unreal**, like the hare's horn — which this phenomenal world manifestly is not. Hence the world is neither real nor unreal in the absolute sense; this is precisely what shows its self-contradictory and therefore ultimately incomprehensible nature. It is relative, phenomenal, finite — but it is not illusory. It is *true for all practical purposes*, and it makes no difference to ordinary worldly people whether or not it is absolutely true in the strict philosophical sense.



When 'reality' is denied to this world, what is actually denied is 'reality for all time'; when 'unreality' is attributed to it, what is attributed is simply 'non-eternality'. Who, then, can seriously deny that the world is 'unreal', if 'unreal' means only 'non-eternal'? Again, the world will be sublated only when knowledge actually dawns, and not before. This consideration should lead us to strive humbly after true knowledge rather than waste ourselves in futile verbal quarrels. Śaṅkara's intention, Sharma concludes, is perfectly clear: none can rightly condemn this world as unreal; he who does so is *not qualified* to do so, and he who is qualified to do so *will not do so* — for he would, by that very qualification, have risen above language and finite thought altogether.



## CHAPTER XI

# ĪŚVARA AND BRAHMAN

### 1. From Unconditioned Brahman to Conditioned Īśvara

Brahman is the only Reality. It is absolutely indeterminate and non-dual, beyond speech and mind, indescribable because no description of it can ever be complete. Its best description is through the negative formula of *neti neti* — 'not this, not this'. Yet Brahman is not an abyss of mere non-entity, because it is the Supreme Self and stands self-revealed as the very background of all affirmations and denials whatsoever.

The moment we try to bring Brahman within the categories of the intellect, or try to make this ultimate *subject* into an *object* of our thought, we necessarily miss its essential nature. It then no longer remains Unconditioned Consciousness but becomes conditioned, *as it were*. This Brahman, reflected in or conditioned by *Māyā*, is called **Īśvara**, or God. Īśvara is the personal aspect of the impersonal Brahman — this is the celebrated distinction between God and the Absolute which Śaṅkara, following the Upaniṣads, draws. Īśvara is also known as *Apara Brahma* (lower Brahman), as contrasted with the unconditioned Brahman, called *Para Brahma* (Higher Brahman).

### 2. Why Īśvara Is Not, For Us, 'Unreal'

The phenomenal character of Īśvara is quite evident — He is the highest appearance we have. Some critics have missed the true significance of Īśvara, believing that Īśvara in Advaita is simply unreal and useless. This is a serious mistake, rooted in a failure to grasp the true significance of *Māyā*. Īśvara becomes 'unreal' only for *him* who has already realised his own oneness with Brahman by rising above speech and mind altogether. For us — for all who have not yet so realised — Īśvara is all in all. Finite thought can never grasp Brahman as such; therefore all talk about Brahman is, in effect, really talk about Īśvara. Even the words 'unconditioned Brahman' refer, in practice, to 'conditioned Īśvara' — for the very moment we speak of Brahman, He ceases, in that speaking, to be Brahman and becomes Īśvara.

### 3. The Nature and Attributes of Īśvara

Īśvara, or God, is Sat-Chit-Ānanda — Existence-Consciousness-Bliss. He is the Perfect Personality. He is the Lord of *Māyā*. He is immanent in the whole universe, which He controls from within — He is the Soul of souls as well as the Soul of Nature. As the immanent inner ruler He is called **Antaryāmin**. He is equally transcendental, for in His own nature He transcends the universe altogether. He is the Creator, Sustainer and Destroyer of this universe; the Source of everything; the final haven of everything. He is the Concrete Universal, the Supreme Individual, the Whole, the Identity-in-difference. He is the object of devotion and the inspirer of moral life. He is, in short, all in all from the practical standpoint. Sharma notes that the description of Brahman which Rāmānuja offered at a considerably later date is, in essence, simply an elaboration of Śaṅkara's own conception of Īśvara.

## 4. The Impossibility of Proving God by Reason — The Kantian Parallel

Śaṅkara, like Kant, holds that God cannot be *proved* by finite thought. All attempts to do so end in failure and lead to what Kant called the antinomies:

- (i) The **cosmological proof** can give us, at best, only a finite creator of this finite creation — and a finite creator is, strictly, no creator at all.
- (ii) The **teleological proof** can only point to the fact that some conscious principle is at work at the root of creation; it cannot establish more than this.
- (iii) The **ontological proof** can give us only an *idea* of God, never God as a real object.
- (iv) The Nyāya arguments offered to prove the existence of God are, on this view, ultimately futile.

God, therefore, is an article of faith. Śruti is the only proof for the existence of God — just as Kant, having exhausted the rational proofs, falls back on faith, so Śaṅkara falls back on Śruti. Śaṅkara further agrees with Gauḍapāda's doctrine of *Ajāti* (non-origination): there is, ultimately, no *real* creation at all. God, therefore, is not a 'real' Creator in any ultimate sense; God alone is real, and the creation is only an appearance of God.

## 5. Three Theories of the Īśvara-Jīva-Brahman Relation

Īśvara has been a genuinely taxing problem for Śaṅkara's later followers, who developed several competing theories of exactly how Īśvara and Jīva relate to Brahman:

### (a) Reflection Theory (*Pratibimbavāda*)

On this view, Īśvara is the reflection of Brahman in Māyā, while Jīva is the reflection of Brahman in Avidyā. **Difficulty:** since Brahman and Māyā are both formless, how can a formless original ever be reflected in a formless receptacle? To escape this difficulty, some proposed the further doctrine of the **Identity of the Original and the Reflected Image** (*bimbapratibimbābheda*) — but this too proved unacceptable.

### (b) Limitation Theory (*Avacchedavāda*)

On this alternative view, Brahman limited or conditioned by Māyā is Īśvara, while Brahman limited by Avidyā, or by the internal organ (itself a product of Avidyā), is Jīva. **Difficulty:** how can Māyā or Avidyā possibly constitute a genuine limitation upon Brahman, which is by definition unlimited?

### (c) Appearance Theory (*Ābhāsavāda*)

A third group, dissatisfied with both preceding theories, holds that Īśvara and Jīva are simply *inexplicable appearances* of Brahman (*ābhāsavāda*). Some also regard Jīva specifically as the reflection of Īśvara.

Sharma's judgment is that the post-Śaṅkarites have here indulged in needless hair-splitting; the problem was never a taxing one for Śaṅkara himself. He freely uses the similes of the reflection of the Sun or Moon in waves or in different vessels of

water, of the reflection of the red colour of a flower in a crystal, and of the limitation of universal space into different 'spaces in jars' — but he uses these only for their *suggestive value* as metaphors, never intending them to be taken literally or stressed beyond breaking point. Śaṅkara himself seems to favour the **Appearance Theory**, since for him Īśvara and Jīva are the inexplicable appearances of Brahman, due to Māyā, Avidyā, or Adhyāsa — mere appearances (vivarta). The 'why' and the 'how' of Avidyā are, on this view, illegitimate questions and therefore an insoluble mystery in principle.

## 6. God's Self-Experience versus the Jīva's

God is God only *to the jīva* who is labouring under Avidyā. God Himself never feels Himself to be God at all; He feels Himself to be essentially one with Brahman, since Avidyā, in its negative aspect of concealment, never operates upon Him. God is the Lord of Māyā, while the jīva is constantly troubled by Māyā; God always enjoys the Bliss of Brahman, while the jīva is tortured by the pangs of Avidyā.

*Footnote: sa īśo yad vaśe māyā sa jīvo yastayārditaḥ — he in whose control Māyā stands is Īśvara; he who is afflicted by it is the jīva.*

When Brahman is viewed as saṁsāra, God, Soul and Nature arise simultaneously; and when Brahman's own essence is realised, God, Soul and Nature vanish simultaneously together with it.

## CHAPTER XII

# JĪVA AND BRAHMAN

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### 1. The Phenomenal Difference Between Jīva and Īśvara

Qualified Brahman is Īśvara. Phenomenally, there is a genuine difference between Jīva and Īśvara: the former is the agent and the enjoyer, who acquires merit and demerit and experiences pleasure and pain, while the latter is not touched by any of this at all. The Muṇḍaka (III, 1, 1) famously declares that 'one bird eats the sweet fruit, while the other merely looks on'. The Jīva *enjoys* (pibati); Īśvara *makes him enjoy* (pāyayati). One is the enjoyer, the other the ruler. The Kaṭha (I, 3, 1; III, 3, 34) states, more figuratively, that both of these 'enjoy' in the manner of two people sharing one umbrella (*chatrīṇyāyena*) — but Sharma stresses this is only a figurative concession, since ultimately there is no difference whatsoever between Jīva and Brahman.

### 2. Tat Tvam Asi and the Realisation of the True Self

Only so long as the jīva fails to discard the Nescience that leads to duality, and fails to realise its own true nature, does it remain an individual self. Slumbering in ignorance, when it is awakened by the Śruti, the jīva realises that it is not the body, the senses, or the mind, but is in truth the non-dual universal Self — *tat tvam asi*, 'that thou art'. Realising his own true nature in this way, the jīva ever after dwells in himself, shining forth in his true nature.

### 3. The False Notions Constituting the Empirical Jīva

Through ignorance, the jīva is regarded as tinged with the false notions of 'I' and 'Mine', notions which arise when the mind, operating through the senses, comes into contact with fleeting sensations and ideas. Under ignorance, the jīva is variously viewed:

- as something wholly different from the eternal and self-luminous Consciousness that is its own immanent inner controller;
- as the mere reflection of that Consciousness;
- as identical with the mind and its fleeting states;
- as associated with the seed of ignorance itself;
- as the possessor of merely momentary ideas.

As long as these false notions about the self persist, the result is precisely the empirical self together with its objective world; and when these notions are destroyed by right knowledge, the result is liberation — though, ultimately, both bondage and liberation are themselves only phenomenal, since the jīva is really non-different from Brahman throughout. Even the statement that the jīva 'becomes' Brahman is, strictly, only a verbal or figurative manner of speaking (*upacāramātra*), for the jīva is, in truth, always Brahman already.

### 4. The Reflection Analogies

A recurring set of analogies illustrates how the one Self appears to become many under Nescience: a pure, transparent white crystal is wrongly imagined to be red on account of a red flower placed near it; the colourless sky is wrongly imagined by the ignorant to be sullied with dirt; a rope is wrongly mistaken for a snake in the twilight; a shell is mistaken for silver. In exactly the same way, the non-dual Ātman or Brahman is wrongly imagined to be the limited empirical self. Just as the Sun or the Moon appears to be many on account of its reflection in different waves or vessels of water, or as the same single space appears to be many different 'spaces' on account of the adjuncts of jars, so too the same one Self appears as so many distinct phenomenal selves purely on account of Nescience.

## 5. Śaṅkara's Polemic Against Reifying the Jīva-Brahman Difference

Śaṅkara states plainly that he who wants to interpret Scripture as teaching that the jīva is not really Brahman — and who thereby wants to preserve the ultimate reality of bondage and liberation as such — is, in fact, the lowest among the learned (*paṇḍitāpasada*).

The entire purpose of refuting such speculations, which only hinder the realisation of the essential unity of the self, and of establishing that there is only one real Self — eternal and unchanging, the Luminous Body of Pure Consciousness (*Vijñāna-dhātu*) — which, through its own power, manifests itself as many, and beyond which there is no other Reality whatsoever, is, Sharma states, precisely the aim of the Śārīraka-Bhāṣya, Śaṅkara's commentary on the Brahma-Sūtras.

## CHAPTER XIII

# ĀTMAN AND BRAHMAN

### 1. Ātman as Brahman: Definition

Ātman is the same as Brahman. It is Pure Consciousness — the Self which is self-luminous and which transcends the subject-object duality and the entire trinity of knower, known and knowledge, along with all the categories of the intellect. It is the Unqualified Absolute; it is the only Reality. Brahman is everything, and everything is Brahman. There is, ultimately, no duality and no diversity at all.

### 2. The Self-Evidence of the Self (Svayāmsiddha) — The Full Set of Arguments

Sharma lists, in sequence, the arguments by which Śaṅkara establishes that the Self is self-proved and beyond all possible denial:

- This Self can never be denied, for the very idea of denial itself presupposes it.
- It cannot be doubted, for all doubt whatsoever rests upon it.
- All assertions, all doubts, and all denials alike presuppose it.
- It is not adventitious or derived (āgantuka); it is self-proved or original (svayāmsiddha).
- All the means of cognition (pramāṇas) are themselves founded upon it.
- To refute this Self is a strict impossibility, for he who tries to refute it is, in that very act, the Self.
- The knower knows no change, for eternal existence is its very nature (*na jñātur anyathābhāvo'sti sarvadā vartamānasvabhāvāt*).
- 'Never is the sight of the seer destroyed' — so declares the Bṛhadāraṇyaka.
- 'He who knows Brahman becomes Brahman' (*Brahma veda Brahmaiva bhavati*).
- He who is the knower is, in fact, the Self itself, for he is omnipresent.
- Everything else whatsoever is relative and therefore ultimately unreal; the Self alone is not relative, and it is, therefore, self-proved (*yaddhi anapekṣam tat svata eva siddham*).

### 3. The Tragedy of the Human Intellect

The tragedy of the human intellect, on this account, is that it invariably tries to know everything as an *object*. But whatever can be presented as an object is, for that very reason, necessarily relative, and therefore unreal. The knower can never be known as an object. Ultimately, there is no distinction at all between the true knower and pure knowledge itself. 'How, O dear, can the knower be known?' asks the Bṛhadāraṇyaka. Hence all those who rely purely on the intellect are deluded, because they can never truly describe the Self either as existent or as non-existent. The Self is essentially indescribable, since all descriptions and all categories alike

fail to grasp it fully.

#### 4. Brahman as Sat-Chit-Ānanda — and Beyond All Determination

Brahman ultimately transcends all categories whatsoever. The best method of describing it is, therefore, by negative terms. Yet if we wish to describe it positively, the best that can be said is that it is Pure Consciousness, which is at once Pure Existence and Pure Bliss. We cannot, strictly, even say that Brahman is self-conscious *of* its own consciousness, or that it *enjoys* its own bliss — these are determinations proper to the intellect, and they fail to apply here. The fact is that Brahman itself simply *is* Pure Existence, Pure Consciousness and Pure Bliss, all in one — it is its very nature to be so. It cannot be regarded as a substance possessing these as qualities, nor even as a subject that knows or feels these qualities. All distinctions of substance and quality, of subject and object, all determinations of the intellect whatsoever, simply cease here.

Dvaita, or dualism, does not, on this view, deserve to be positively taught at all, since everybody already assumes it as a matter of course in all phenomenal practice. The Śāstra, therefore, takes the normal dualism that people naturally take for granted, on account of transcendental ignorance, and teaches that although dualism is a practical necessity, it is not ultimately real. Brahman is the only reality; it is the End (*upeya*); and Brahmanvidyā — the knowledge of the non-difference of the individual self (*jīvātman*) and the Supreme Self (*Paramātman*) — is the means (*upāya*) of realising this end. Once the end is realised, the Śāstra itself is transcended and left behind.

#### 5. Existence, Consciousness, and the Logical Exhaustion of Alternatives

Existence and Consciousness are one — Sharma here draws an explicit parallel with the Hegelian formula that the Real is the Rational and the Rational is the Real. Yet ultimately Brahman is devoid of all characteristics whatsoever, as the following exhaustive set of exclusions shows:

- Brahman cannot be defined as mere Existence and not Consciousness, for the Śāstra declares it to be All-Consciousness (*viññānaghana*).
- Nor can it be defined as mere Consciousness and not Existence, for the Śāstra simply says 'it is'.
- Nor can it be defined as both Existence and Consciousness together, for to admit that Brahman is characterised by an Existence different from Consciousness, or by a Consciousness different from Existence, is already to admit an illegitimate duality within Brahman itself.
- Nor can it be defined as characterised by an Existence that is non-different from Consciousness, for if Existence simply *is* Consciousness and Consciousness simply *is* Existence, there could be no controversy at all as to whether Brahman is Existence or Consciousness or both — the very existence of the controversy shows the inadequacy of every formulation offered.



Sharma adds a final logical point: to say that Reality *exists* but is not *known* is a contradiction in terms, since at the very least Reality is known precisely *as* unknowable by the intellect — exactly as it would be self-contradictory to say that 'coloured objects exist, but there is no eye to see them.' Reality must, therefore, exist for us, and it is only Pure Consciousness that can ultimately exist in this sense. We cannot know it through the finite intellect, but we can realise it directly, through pure intuition.

## 6. The Total Transcendence of All Dualities

It is non-dual Consciousness in which all distinctions, all plurality, all determinations, all qualities, all characteristics, all categories and all concepts whatsoever are transcended. All determinations of language and of intellect are merged in this indeterminate and unqualified Reality. The following pairs, among others, simply do not apply to the Absolute: being and not-being; one and many; qualified and unqualified; knowledge and ignorance; action and inaction; active and inactive; fruitful and fruitless; seedful and seedless; pleasure and pain; middle and not-middle; śūnya and aśūnya; soul and God; unity and plurality. He who wishes to grasp the Absolute through any of these determinations is, in effect, trying to roll up the sky like a skin, or trying to climb space like a stair-case, or wishing to see the footprints of fish in water or of birds in the sky.

## 7. Neti Neti — Its Meaning and Its Limit

The Śāstra, therefore, ultimately falls silent after saying 'not this, not this' (*neti neti*). Sharma offers a striking illustration of the logic here: if a man does not understand that he is a man when told merely that he is *not* a non-man, how could he possibly understand it any better if simply told, flatly, that he *is* a man? The two 'no's in the formula 'neti neti' are meant precisely to emphasise the single fact that whatever can be presented as an object is, for that very reason, ultimately unreal. They cover the entire field of objective existence and point out, in each case, that it is not real. There is no better way of describing the Absolute than this negative method — but it should never be forgotten that all these negations presuppose, and point towards, the positive Brahman that underlies them.

The Absolute can be unknowable only for those who remain ignorant of the Vedānta tradition, who do not know the proper means of right knowledge, and who cling desperately to the world. It is true that the Absolute cannot be known as an *object* by the intellect. But, being the only Reality, and being always present and therefore never in fact foreign to us, it is directly realised through spiritual experience (*samyagjñāna*). The phrase 'neti neti' negates all the *characteristics* of Brahman, but it does not negate Brahman itself — it implies precisely that there is *something* about which something is being denied. Appearances can be negated only with reference to an underlying Reality; effects alone can be negated, since effects alone are unreal. But the cause, Brahman itself, can never be negated, for it is the ultimate ground upon which all effects, all phenomena, are superposed in the first place.

## CHAPTER XIV

# KNOWLEDGE AND ACTION

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### 1. Knowledge Alone Is the Means to Liberation

Śaṅkara repeatedly asserts that the Absolute can be realised through knowledge, and through knowledge alone; karma (ritual action) and upāsanā (meditative worship) are strictly subsidiary. They may certainly help by urging us towards the knowledge of Reality, and may prepare us for that knowledge by purifying the mind (*sattvaśuddhi*) — but ultimately it is knowledge alone which, by destroying ignorance, the root-cause of this entire world, can enable us to become one with the Absolute.

### 2. The Doctrine of Jñāna-Karma-Virodha

The opposition between knowledge and action stands as firm as a mountain in Śaṅkara's system. They are contradictory (*viparīte*) and are poles apart (*dūramete*). Those who speak of combining knowledge with action, Śaṅkara says, have perhaps simply never read the Bṛhadāraṇyaka, nor are they aware of the glaring contradiction repeatedly pointed out on this score by both the Śruti and the Smṛti. Knowledge and action are opposed exactly as light is opposed to darkness. Actions are prescribed only for those who remain in ignorance, and not for those who are already enlightened. Knowledge does nothing more than remove ignorance — and once ignorance is removed, Reality simply shines forth by itself, without further assistance from action.

### 3. The Liberated Sage and Continued Action

A liberated sage, nevertheless, continues to perform actions — but does so without any attachment, and works purely for the uplift of humanity. Śaṅkara's own life, Sharma observes, bears ample witness to this fact: the rejection of karma as a *means* to liberation does not entail the cessation of action altogether once liberation is attained.

## CHAPTER XV

## KNOWLEDGE AND LIBERATION

## 1. Knowledge as Purely Informative, Not Productive

Ultimate Reality (*pāramārthikam vastu*) can neither be asserted nor denied by knowledge. Knowledge does nothing at all except remove ignorance. The Śāstra only generates right knowledge (*jñāpakam*) — it does nothing else whatsoever; it is not an agent of production (*na kārakam*).

## 2. Knowledge of Brahman versus Religious Action — A Fundamental Contrast

Knowledge of Brahman, which leads to eternal bliss, does not depend upon the performance of any act, for Brahman is already an *accomplished fact*. Religious acts which lead to worldly prosperity, by contrast, depend entirely upon human performance. Religious texts, accordingly, enjoin injunctions or prohibitions regarding action — but knowledge merely *instructs*. Knowledge of Brahman culminates in immediate experience and is, from the outset, already an accomplished fact. Action — whether secular or Vedic — can be done, misdones, or simply left undone; injunctions, prohibitions, options, rules and exceptions all depend, in the end, on our own thinking and choice. Knowledge, however, leaves us *no such option* regarding its being this way or that, or regarding its existence or non-existence: it is not within our power to make, unmake, or change knowledge at will. Our thinking cannot make a pillar into a man.

## 3. Six Marks of True Knowledge

Knowledge of Brahman, therefore, depends on Brahman itself, and is always of the same nature because it depends on the existent thing (*brahmajñānam vastutantram*). Sharma draws out the following properties of true knowledge from Śaṅkara's account:

- It is produced by the Pramāṇas and conforms strictly to its objects.
- It can neither be produced by hundreds of injunctions, nor can it be destroyed by hundreds of prohibitions.
- It is not mental activity, since it depends not on the mind but on the existent fact itself.
- There is no succession in knowledge — it does not arrive in installments.
- Once it dawns, it dawns forever, and at once removes all ignorance, and consequently all bondage together with it.
- Liberation, therefore, is nothing other than the removal of ignorance by knowledge (*mokṣapratibandhanivṛttimātram eva ātmajñānasya phalam*).

## 4. Jīvanmukti and Videhamukti

That blessed person who has realised Reality is liberated *here and now* — this is **Jīvanmukti**, liberation while still embodied. The Śruti offers the image: 'just as a

slough cast off by a snake lies on an ant-hill, similarly does this body lie' — the body persists, discarded, while the liberated self has already moved beyond it. **Final release** (*Videhamukti*) is obtained only after the actual death of the body; as the Śruti puts it, 'the only delay for him is the death of the body.'

Just as a potter's wheel continues to revolve for some time even after the initial push has been withdrawn, so too the body may continue to exist for some time even after knowledge has dawned, even though all attachment to the body has already been cut off at the root. Like an arrow already shot from the bow, the body continues to travel its course and reap the fruits of past actions already set in motion, until it finally expires — but no *new* actions are accumulated by the liberated sage from this point onward.

## CHAPTER XVI

## ULTIMATE CRITERION OF TRUTH

Sharma frames this chapter around a three-way contest: Revelation, Reason and Intuition each lay claim to being crowned as the ultimate criterion of truth within Śaṅkara's system.

### 1. The Supremacy of Śruti — But Only of Its Jñānakāṇḍa

Śaṅkara attaches supreme importance to the revealed truths of the Vedas, regarded as the very 'breath of God' (*yasya niḥśvasitaṃ vedāḥ*). But it is specifically the **jñānakāṇḍa** — the knowledge-portion of the Veda — that is stressed by him, and not the **karmakāṇḍa**, the ritual-action portion.

Whoever condemns Śaṅkara as a mere theologian 'whose faith is pinned to the Vedas', Sharma insists, must be either hopelessly ignorant of Śaṅkara-Vedānta, or else must himself be nothing less than a prejudiced dogmatist. Śaṅkara never accepts the Śruti blindly. It is only because he fully recognises that the Śruti embodies the result of the highest realisation of the ancient sages — that it is, in effect, the most valuable pearl that the entire ocean of human experience has ever yielded, after having been churned by the rod of the intellect — in short, it is only because Śaṅkara is fully conscious that the Śruti is shining pure gold, already tested at the touchstone of reason and experience, that he builds his many-storeyed and magnificent palace of Advaita on the firm foundation of the Śruti.

Brahman, being supersensuous, can be realised only through Revelation or Śruti. Even here, however, intellect is not driven out of the palace of philosophy altogether — it is retained there as an ancillary to what Sharma calls 'the Revelation-Queen'.

### 2. The Limits of Discursive Intellect

Śaṅkara repeatedly asserts that discursive intellect cannot, on its own, grasp Reality. Brahman cannot become the object of perception, since it has no form; and it does not lend itself to inference or to any of the other means of knowledge, since it possesses no characteristic mark (*liṅga*) by which it could be inferred. Partly accepting the position of Bhartṛhari — a position that is itself criticised by Śāntaraksita — Śaṅkara observes that reasoning, precisely because it depends on individual reasoners, has no solid or stable foundation of its own: arguments held valid by some may always be shown fallacious by others more ingenious than they. Like Asaṅga, Śaṅkara declares intellect to be fundamentally insecure on its own and emphasises the Āgama (scriptural transmission) instead. But his criticism, Sharma stresses, is directed specifically towards **kutarka** — dry, merely destructive logical quibbling — and not against reasoning as such.

### 3. Kutarka Condemned, Sutarka Vindicated

Śruti, says Śaṅkara, cannot be set aside by mere logical quibbling. A false logician is simply a quibbler who says whatever he pleases. Those whose minds are fouled by such

quibbling are to be pitied, because they do not know the tradition of the Vedānta at all. What grand feats of reasoning, Śaṅkara asks with evident scorn, are really displayed by such logicians — who are like bulls without horns and without tails! They are princes among liars, and among those who violate the tradition of the wise. They cannot enter the Fort of Brahman, which stands open only to those of excellent wisdom who possess both the knowledge of the Śāstra and the blessings of a teacher. Debaters, Śaṅkara says, fight against one another like carnivorous animals contending over bait, and fall away from Reality in the process; themselves deluded, they go on to delude innocent people besides. It is only for the sake of those who genuinely desire liberation — which can be obtained by knowledge alone — that false views should be rejected at all; Śaṅkara insists that he himself criticises rival doctrines for this reason alone, and never out of any mere love of disputation for its own sake.

It is, therefore, only logical quibbling, or *kutarka*, that stands condemned in Śaṅkara. **Sutarka**, or refined and disciplined intellect, is by contrast admitted as supreme within the phenomenal world, where its authority is said to be wholly unquestionable. Only an intellectual — a rational being — can understand the meaning of the Śruti at all; the Śruti cannot reveal itself to a beast. As Yāska observed, he who merely reads or memorises the Veda without understanding its meaning is no better than a coolie carrying a load of the Veda upon his head — indeed, he is no better than a pillar. Śaṅkara never asks us to accept the Śruti blindly; he is never satisfied with a bare quotation from scripture on a vital metaphysical issue, and always goes on to defend that quotation with reasoned argument.

#### 4. Reason as Arbiter Among Conflicting Scriptural Passages

If we encounter apparent contradictions within the Śruti, we should interpret the disputed passages in the light of that one central doctrine of the Śruti which itself appeals most strongly to reason. And if the Śruti should contradict reason outright, then reason itself must be our guide, since reason is nearer to our own experience. Even if a hundred Śrutis were to declare, with a single voice, that fire is cool and without light, or that the Sun does not shine, we still could not accept them. Reason, on this account, is the sole means of distinguishing truth from falsity.

#### 5. The Self-Referential Status of Reason

We cannot, Sharma notes, question the validity of the intellect within the phenomenal world at all. Here, in Śaṅkara's own memorable phrase, 'you obey while you rebel' — even the very statement that 'intellect stands condemned' must itself be made by the intellect. Reason cannot be dethroned except by an act of reasoning, which already presupposes its authority.

#### 6. Infra-Relational Instinct versus Supra-Relational Intuition

Infra-relational intuition is nothing more than mere animal instinct, whereas supra-relational *true* intuition is identical with Pure Reason itself. **Svānubhava**, or **Svānubhūti** — immediate experience, or direct self-realisation — is identical with Pure Consciousness. Here, finite intellect casts off entirely the garb of relationality that had

been placed upon it by ignorance, and becomes one with the Absolute, which is itself Pure Consciousness.

## **7. The 'Suicide' of Discursive Intellect as Its Own Consecration**

Discursive intellect, Sharma concludes, confesses its own impotence only in order to be rejuvenated with new life and eternal vigour; and what appears, from one angle, to be its own suicide is, in fact, its own consecration. Shall we not say, then, with a deeper meaning, that the ultimate criterion of truth in Śaṅkara is, in this truer sense, immediate spiritual realisation itself?